

Postdoctoral Award: application guidance

Use this career development award guidance to help you prepare your application. This guidance lists all the fields that appear in the online application form, and explains what information you need to include in each one.

What should you use this guidance for?

You should use this guidance if you are applying for a funding opportunity through the [Postdoctoral Award \(/node/31536\)](#).

Setting up your NIHR awards management system account

All funding applications need to be submitted through our [NIHR awards management system](#) (https://awardsmanagement.nihr.ac.uk/s_Login.jsp). If you do not already have an account, please visit the awards management system and follow the on-screen instructions.

We recommend starting your application as soon as possible to ensure you have plenty of time to get all of your team members and organisations registered on the system, if they are not already. There are multiple steps involved in creating an account. Please contact the relevant programme team as soon as possible if you have any questions, so they can assist you before the submission deadline. To do this, log in to the [awards management system](#) (https://awardsmanagement.nihr.ac.uk/s_Login.jsp) and raise a help ticket. Click 'Request help' which you can find at the top of each tab in the awards management system within your application.

When you first use the awards management system, you will need to complete our diversity monitoring questions before you can submit an application. If you next log in after 12 months, you will need to review and verify your responses. For more information about why we collect this data, see our [diversity data FAQs \(/about-us/who-we-are/research-inclusion/diversity-data\)](/about-us/who-we-are/research-inclusion/diversity-data).

NIHR requirements

When completing your funding application, please ensure you are aware of NIHR requirements around [working with people and communities \(/research-funding/application-support/working-with-people-and-communities\)](/research-funding/application-support/working-with-people-and-communities), [research inclusion \(/about-us/who-we-are/research-inclusion/global-health-research-funding-application-guidance\)](/about-us/who-we-are/research-inclusion/global-health-research-funding-application-guidance) and [knowledge mobilisation \(/research-funding/application-support/plan-knowledge-mobilisation\)](/research-funding/application-support/plan-knowledge-mobilisation). We also encourage you to consider the [environmental impact of your research \(/about-us/what-we-do/key-initiatives/climate-health-sustainability/carbon-reduction-guidelines\)](/about-us/what-we-do/key-initiatives/climate-health-sustainability/carbon-reduction-guidelines) in line with [our climate, health and sustainability commitments \(/our-commitments-climate-health-and-sustainability-2024-2026\)](/our-commitments-climate-health-and-sustainability-2024-2026).

If you use generative AI to prepare a funding application, you must clearly cite and acknowledge this.

About the application form

On the home page of the awards management system, click on 'Funding opportunities', search for the funding opportunity you are applying to and click the 'Apply Now' button.

When you start your application, you will see an overview of the funding opportunity.

The application form is divided into tabs. Please read everything carefully and complete all the mandatory sections. At the bottom of your screen there are 3 buttons: 'Save draft', 'Info still required' and 'Submit'. Regularly save your answers by clicking the 'Save draft' button. Use the 'Info still required' button to keep a check on which sections you still need to complete. Click on the 'Submit' button to submit your application. If there is any

outstanding information, you will see a 'Submission failed' message with a list of the missing information.

Please start your application early and allow plenty of time to complete it. All applications must be written in English. Check the character limit for each field and make sure you keep within the limits. The character count includes spaces and if you go over the character limit, your text will be cut off. Please also check the page limit for each upload because these are a large part of your application.

If you have added other people to your application, such as signatories, they will need to confirm their involvement before you submit your application. Please check the award specific information for details of who needs to contribute to your application.

Use the guidance below, alongside the relevant [funding opportunity information \(/funding-opportunities\)](#) and [award page details \(/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-fellowships\)](#), to help you answer the questions in our online application form. Please read all the guidance before starting your application. You will find some in-application guidance to help you. You can also access on-screen instructions in the awards management system by clicking the (i) symbol.

You might also find the following information helpful:

- our [glossary \(/glossary\)](#) for using if you come across any terms you are not sure of when reading our guidance
- the [assessment criteria \(/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award/assessment-criteria\)](#) for this award

The section headings in this guidance correspond to the tabs in the awards management system.

Uploads

The following uploads can be provided as part of your application:

- references (mandatory)
- Gantt chart or project management plan (mandatory)
- letters of support (mandatory)
- devolved administration confirmation letter (if applicable)
- narrative CV (mandatory)
- detailed research plan – (mandatory)
- career development programme – (mandatory)
- Schedule of Events Cost Attribution Tool (SoECAT) (if applicable)

You should only include uploads specified in the guidance for the funding opportunity you are applying for. Any additional documents will not be considered by the committee during its review and may be removed.

You should upload your documents into the application form once you have completed them. To do this, you can drag and drop documents, or click ‘browse files’ to locate them on your device.

Only the following document types can be uploaded: .doc, .docx, .xlsx and .pdf.

Please convert all document types to PDF format before uploading into the system, to ensure formatting is consistent. If you upload a Word document (.doc or .docx), the system will create a PDF version of it which may display formatting differently. Both the Word document and system PDF will appear in the ‘Uploads’ section. Please do not delete the PDF versions that the system creates and adds to your application, unless you wish to remove or replace any of your uploads entirely, in which case you will need to delete both versions.

Summary information

The 'Summary information' section asks some questions about you and your application.

Contracting and partner organisations

Your contracting organisation and partner organisation, if applicable, can be:

- a higher education institute
- an NHS body
- a local authority or other provider of health or social care services

Contracting and partner organisations must be in England or a participating devolved nation. Refer to the funding opportunity page for details of participating devolved nations for the funding opportunity you are applying to.

You must have either a substantive employment contract or an honorary contract with the contracting organisation for the duration of your award. You can choose to be employed by either your proposed contracting organisation or a named partner organisation.

You must name an eligible contracting organisation. You must also name a partner organisation if:

1. your employer for the duration of the award will not be your contracting organisation
 - in this case the employing organisation needs to be an eligible organisation for the funding opportunity and you must name it as a partner organisation
 - you will need to hold an honorary contract for the duration of the award with the contracting organisation
2. you are requesting salaried clinical or practice time through the award, but you will not undertake it within your contracting organisation

- in this case, you must name the organisation where you will practise as a partner organisation

Find out more about choosing your [contracting organisation and employment options \(/career-development/nih-academy/apply-nih-career-development-awards/choosing-contracting-organisation-career-development-awards\)](#).

A partner organisation will support you to undertake your award but does not hold the contract for the award. A partner organisation may also be where you choose to undertake some of your research activities.

You can identify a maximum of 1 partner organisation.

Contracting organisation

The contracting organisation will be the contractor if your application is funded.

You must check you have chosen the most appropriate organisation. They have overall responsibility for supporting successful completion of the programme of work detailed in your application, if your application is successful. Once a funding decision has been made, a formal approval process would need to be followed if you wish to request a change to the contracting organisation.

The contractor must fulfil the following in the usual project timeframes:

- respond to required financial reconciliation exercises
- provide the final financial reconciliation statement for the award
- provide ad-hoc requests for financial information during the lifetime of the award
- respond to any queries relating to intellectual property, commercialisation and benefit realisation

The contractor must fulfil the role of research sponsor. A sponsor is the organisation directly responsible for securing the arrangements to initiate, manage, and finance your award. They must follow the guidelines set out in the [NHS's UK policy framework for health and social care research](https://www.hra.nhs.uk/planning-and-improving-research/policies-standards-legislation/uk-policy-framework-health-social-care-research/) (<https://www.hra.nhs.uk/planning-and-improving-research/policies-standards-legislation/uk-policy-framework-health-social-care-research/>).

You will need to add your contracting organisation to your application form. To add your proposed contracting organisation, click on the drop-down and start typing the name into the search box at the top. A maximum of 10 organisations appear in the list so you may need to refine your search until the option you want appears. If you can't find your organisation in the list, please check the way the organisation name is spelled.

If the organisation you are looking for does not appear, the next question will ask if you found your contracting organisation. If you select 'no', you can request to 'Add new contracting organisation'. Our systems team will need to approve and add the new organisation before you can submit your application. Please request this change as early as possible. We recommend you give us at least 2 weeks' notice before the funding opportunity closing date.

Before you apply, you must ask a representative of the contracting organisation, for example head of department or head of school, if they are happy to support your application. You must upload a letter of support from the contracting organisation as part of your application.

The representative at your contracting organisation must accept their participation in the application. They must also electronically sign your application after you have submitted it. Please see the signatories section of this guidance for details.

Please check for any restrictions on contracting organisations.

Contracting organisation department

Please name the department within your contracting organisation that you will be based in for the duration of your award.

Partner organisation(s)

If applicable, please give details of the partner organisation who will be supporting your application. You can identify a maximum of one partner organisation.

If the organisation you are looking for does not appear, you can request to 'Add new contracting organisation'. Our systems team will need to approve and add the new organisation before you can submit your application. Please request this change as early as possible, and at least 2 weeks before the funding opportunity closing date.

A representative from your partner organisation is required to accept their participation in the application and to electronically sign the application after applicant submission. Please see the signatories section below for details. You must upload a letter of support from the partner organisation as part of your application.

Application title (100 characters)

Your application title should clearly and concisely summarise your proposed research. Please write any abbreviations out in full.

Start month and start year

Use the drop-downs to select the month and year your award will start. The start date will be the first day of the month regardless of whether this is a working day or not. This is the first day of funded activity.

Be realistic about your possible start date. This should take account of any contracting, and any staff recruitment needed ahead of starting. Please refer to the application timeline on the specific funding opportunity page for available start dates. You cannot defer an award, unless for statutory reasons.

Duration (months)

The duration is the period of time you will need to complete your award. Enter the number of months as whole numbers only - avoid fractions or decimal numbers. You should take

into account your full time equivalent (FTE) rate when setting your award duration. For example, if the full-time duration for an award is 36 months and you will work at 50% FTE, your award duration would be 72 months.

Make sure you allow enough time to complete all aspects of the award. This includes time for any necessary [regulatory approvals](/research-funding/application-support/regulatory-approvals-governance) (/research-funding/application-support/regulatory-approvals-governance) and for [writing a final report](/research-funding/responsibilities-after-funding/reporting-research) (/research-funding/responsibilities-after-funding/reporting-research).

For a Postdoctoral Award you can:

- choose a duration of between 2 and 5 years 100% full time equivalent (FTE)
- undertake 2 sequential postdoctoral awards, or equivalent predecessor schemes, with a combined duration of up to 8 years FTE

End date

This is the date your award will end. This field will automatically populate using information from the 'Start date' and 'Duration' fields once you click the 'Save draft' button.

% FTE commitment

You can choose to undertake your award on a part-time basis at 5% increments between 50%-100% FTE.

To work out the duration of your award based on your proposed FTE please refer to the Postdoctoral Award section of our [durations page](/personal-career-development-award-durations) (/personal-career-development-award-durations).

Percentage of award-salaried time that will be spent undertaking practice/clinical work

If you are an active clinician or practitioner, or based in a local authority, you can request time dedicated to practice or clinical service to be included in your award.

Time dedicated to professional practice within the award can only be requested by 'active clinicians or practitioners', or 'individuals based in local authority settings':

For this purpose we define 'active clinicians or practitioners' as:

- registered nurses, midwives, allied health professionals, pharmacists and healthcare scientists
- other registered health, public health or social care professionals
- registered doctors or dentists

We define 'individuals based in local authority settings' as people who are employed by:

- local authorities
- providers of local authority commissioned services
- non-profit organisations that provide services on behalf of a local authority or support a local authority in meeting its objectives

If you will not be undertaking funded clinical or practice time as part of the award please input '0'

If you are not an active clinician or practitioner, or based in a local authority, please input '0'.

If you intend to undertake practice outside of the award time, please input '0'.

If you will be including funded time dedicated to practice or clinical service within your award time, please confirm here the percentage of time you propose to spend in professional practice as part of your award. You are also required to tell us how your proposed clinical or practice time will complement the research career you are developing. You should include this in the 'Career development' section at the bottom of the 'Application details' tab in the application form.

If you are a clinical or practitioner applicant, or work in a local authority setting, you can dedicate up to 40% of your time to professional practice and development, with this time covered by the award.

Total cost to NIHR

This information will automatically be pulled through from the 'Budget' section. You do not need to do anything here but you will need to complete the 'Budget' section in this application form.

Please see the budget section below for details of what costs are available through this award. Visit our [finance guidance \(/node/67106\)](/node/67106) for more information about how to complete the 'Budget' section, including details about specific funding rates.

Has this application been previously submitted to this or any other funding body?

Please tell us if you have submitted your application previously to this or another NIHR funding opportunity, or another funder. Please select either the 'Yes' or 'No' option.

If you fail to answer accurately or fully, this will be seen as academic misconduct and treated accordingly.

Re-submitting applications to NIHR

Please check the relevant award page for rules on re-applying.

If you have answered yes, please provide:

- **Grant reference**

Please tell us the grant reference number associated with your previous application.

- **Funder**

Please list the name(s) of the funder(s) you previously applied to.

- **Please provide details**

Please tell us why your previous application was declined and how you have changed and improved it in response to feedback.

Partnership award

We partner with industry, charities and other organisations to offer jointly funded opportunities. Visit the funding opportunity page for this award for information on available partnership opportunities for this cohort.

If you are applying to a partnership award, please select the name of the participating partner you are applying to from the drop-down list.

If there are no partnership awards for this funding opportunity, or none are relevant to your application, please select 'Not applicable'.

If you are applying for a partnership award, we may share the following information with the partner organisation for use in the decision-making review process and ongoing monitoring of the award:

- your application form
- assessment information

- your progress during the award
- annual reports
- final and follow up reports

Lead applicant

The 'Lead applicant' section asks some questions about you and your professional background.

It is important that all applicants are registered in the system, and that their details are up to date. If you do not already have an account, please visit the [awards management system](https://awardsmanagement.nihr.ac.uk/s_Login.jsp) (https://awardsmanagement.nihr.ac.uk/s_Login.jsp) and follow the on-screen instructions.

Information on name, primary and other affiliated organisations, and contact details will be automatically populated from each applicant's contact profile within the application system. To add in missing information, or make updates, click the 'My profile' button on the awards management system home page. Or click the 'Update contact profile' button in the relevant sections of your funding application.

As the lead applicant, you must validate your account in our awards management system. You will not be able to submit your application if you have not fully activated your account.

You will need to provide:

Title, first name and surname

These sections of the form will be pre-populated based on your contact profile in the application system. If you need to change any details, click the 'Update' button to edit your profile.

Organisation

The organisation from your contact profile will appear here by default. If you need to change your organisation, click on the 'Update contact profile' button at the top of this section.

If needed, you can add a new organisation to your account by:

1. clicking the 'Update contact profile' button
2. selecting 'Affiliated organisation' in the left-hand selection bar
3. clicking 'Add new organisation'
4. filling out the details of your organisation and press 'Submit'

The organisation listed here should be your current employing organisation. If you intend to move employers in order to undertake the award, select your proposed new employer as your [contracting organisation or partner organisation \(/career-development/nih-academy/apply-nih-career-development-awards/choosing-contracting-organisation-career-development-awards\)](https://career-development/nih-academy/apply-nih-career-development-awards/choosing-contracting-organisation-career-development-awards) in the Summary information section of the application form.

Professional background

Select the option that best describes your professional group. This will determine the subsequent options that appear for your professional background.

Professional registration

Please provide details of any current registration you hold with a professional body.

Professional registration is an eligibility criteria for this award. If you do not provide this information, we will have to reject your application. If you are a clinical applicant you must have completed relevant pre-registration training.

ORCID

In order to submit an application, all applicants are required to provide an [ORCID](https://orcid.org/) (<https://orcid.org/>). This is a free, unique, user identification number used by NIHR and other health research funders.

To obtain an ORCID, or add an existing one to your user contact profile:

1. Click on the 'Home' button in the right-hand corner of the page and then go to the 'My Profile' tab.
2. Add your existing ORCID or register for an ORCID account by clicking on 'Create or connect your ORCID'. This will redirect you to the ORCID website.
3. Sign in to ORCID, or register for an ID number.
4. Within the ORCID system, click on the 'Continue to import your ORCID Data' button.

This will update your contact profile in our application system with your ORCID number.

Please ensure that your ORCID profile is complete and up to date. It will be used as your CV by the NIHR and by the assessors of your application when considering your employment, previous experience and qualifications. We may also use your ORCID profile to confirm your eligibility for the funding opportunity.

Use these sections within your ORCID profile to record and display this information:

- 'Employment'
- 'Education and qualifications'

Your ORCID profile will also be used by the reviewers of your application as the source for your publication record. If you have any research outputs that you want the assessors of your application to be aware of, you must add them to your ORCID profile.

Please [set the visibility of your ORCID account](https://support.orcid.org/hc/en-us/articles/360006894494-Visibility-preferences) (https://support.orcid.org/hc/en-us/articles/360006894494-Visibility-preferences) to 'everyone'. This will allow NIHR and reviewers to access the information.

Adding your ORCID to your application will make the information on your profile accessible to us and our reviewers via its URL. It will not import the information on your ORCID profile into your application form.

You can update and add to your ORCID profile after you have submitted your application, but do not remove any elements that might be of use to NIHR or the assessors of your application until the outcome of your application has been confirmed. We cannot guarantee that the reviewers of your application will see additions that you make after your application has been submitted. Reviewers will only see the information that you have included at the point at which they access the URL.

Research degree status

Please select from the drop-down list the option which best describes the status of your PhD or MD only. If you do not have a PhD/MD, please leave this blank. Please do not enter the status of any bachelors or masters degrees.

You should also answer any follow-up questions about the status of your PhD or MD.

To be eligible, you must hold a relevant PhD or MD, or have submitted your thesis for examination at the time of application. You must have been awarded your PhD or MD by the time you attend the interview.

If you hold a Professional Doctorate, you must contact us before you start your application and we will help to confirm your eligibility.

Contextual factors

Tell us about factors that have impacted the development or outputs of your research career so far. We ask for this information so funding committees can take them into

consideration. If you have no contextual factors to raise, please add 'Not applicable' in this box.

The impact of contextual factors on your career will be specific to your individual circumstances. The factors you list should be significant and relevant to your application. Factors could include but are not limited to:

- career breaks due to parental leave, or periods of illness
- the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic on your research career
- reduced opportunities:
 - to undertake research activities, including research outputs, due to disability, which are physical or mental health related impairments or conditions
 - to undertake research activities due to caring responsibilities
 - for career support, for example mentorship
 - to undertake research and training
 - to obtain grant funding, or to publish research

We acknowledge that you may be reluctant to disclose sensitive information. The information you provide is confidential. We will handle it in-line with [general data and protection regulations \(GDPR\)](#) (/nihr-privacy-policy). We are unable to take into account factors that you do not disclose.

Completing this section of the application form will not automatically make a request for reasonable adjustments. If you require adjustments, please contact the relevant programme team. You can find contact details on the funding opportunity page.

Use of Artificial Intelligence

If you use generative AI when writing your application, you must clearly cite and acknowledge it in this section.

Narrative CV (maximum 3 pages)

You are required to upload a narrative CV as part of your application. Please download the template 'Narrative CV' from within the awards management system.

Please ensure that your narrative CV uses Arial size 12 font and no smaller, and shows page numbers within the document footer. Once you have completed the narrative CV template offline, please convert it into a PDF before uploading into the system to ensure formatting is consistent.

Section headings and margins should not be amended in any way. Upload a maximum of 3 pages.

What is a narrative CV?

A narrative CV is a flexible framework that provides an opportunity for you to showcase relevant contributions and achievements in support of your application. A narrative CV should give more context than a traditional CV. The information you include should demonstrate your ability to successfully deliver the proposed work.

Narrative CVs support our commitment to recognising the wider contributions of applicants to the research system. The format helps us to consider a broad range of skills and experiences that are relevant and transferrable to an opportunity.

How to complete the 'Narrative CV' upload template

You must upload a narrative CV as part of your application. Download the template 'Narrative CV' from within the awards management system and re-upload when it is finalised.

Section headings and margins should not be amended in any way. Please use Arial size 12 font. If your narrative CV exceeds the maximum 3 pages, we will not accept your application.

You will need to decide which of your skills and experiences are relevant to the opportunity to which you are applying. The information you provide must demonstrate your ability to

deliver the proposed work.

Reviewers will also access your ORCID profile to review information on your:

- employment history
- education and qualifications
- publication record, if available and relevant
- other research outputs, if available and relevant

Your ORCID profile should complement your narrative CV. You should refer to information detailed within your ORCID profile when demonstrating your and transferable skills and experience, where relevant.

You must avoid using journal-based metrics, such as journal impact factors and H-index, or institutional rankings when describing your contributions and achievements.

Our narrative CV template contains 4 sections. We have provided examples for each heading as a guide. You are not limited to our examples. You are not required to include an example of each. You can include more than 1 example if they are relevant to your application.

1. Contributions to the generation of new ideas, tools, methodologies or knowledge

Describe how you have contributed to the generation of new ideas, hypotheses, knowledge, tools or techniques, and how this supports your application for the delivery of the proposed work. This could include:

- your key skills or transferable skills relevant to the proposed work

- the process you used to communicate your ideas, develop and test your hypotheses
 - contributions you have made and skills you have acquired from previous roles, including professional role(s) and research projects. If you are an early career researcher, this could include your prior experience of audit, evaluation or quality improvement programmes
 - any previous experience, examples or contributions you have made related to inclusion
 - any awards you have received
 - any funding you have won
 - a small selection of key outputs, including the DOI if available describing how this work is relevant to this application
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2. Contributions to the development of others and maintenance of effective working relationships

Describe how you have contributed to the development of others, and the maintenance of effective working relationships. Include how this supports your application for the delivery of the proposed work.

This could include experience from areas such as:

- project management
- supervision
- mentoring
- line management or leadership

For example, you could evidence these areas by including:

- contributions or expertise you provided which was critical to the success of a team or team members
- development and maintenance of effective working relationships at all levels
- establishment of collaborations or networks within your organisation or beyond
- examples of strategic leadership in shaping the direction of a team, organisation, company or institution
- ways in which you have guided or advised others in their careers
- any previous experience, examples or contributions related to inclusion

3. Contributions to the wider research community

Describe how you have contributed to the wider research community and how this supports your application for the delivery of the proposed work. This could include activities such as:

- committee memberships
- editing and reviewing
- contributions to the evaluation of researchers and research projects
- teaching
- laboratory or technician work
- developing software
- conference or workshop presentation

You could also highlight contributions to increasing research integrity and improving research culture, for example:

- equality, diversity and/or inclusion initiatives
 - activities to improve the mobility of researchers
 - reward and recognition of researchers
 - dissemination
 - policy engagement
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4. Contributions to broader society

Describe how you have contributed to broader society, and how this supports your application for the delivery of the proposed work.

Provide examples of your societal engagement and knowledge exchange. This could include, for example, your engagement with:

- patients, the public and service users
- industry
- private or public sectors
- policy makers
- researchers in different fields or disciplines

Describe how you have ensured that research reaches and influences relevant audiences. For example, your contribution to policy development or public understanding, and other impacts across policy, practice and business.

5. Your suitability for the award

A personal career development award should provide you with a step change in your career trajectory. Use this section to detail the research career that you would like to develop or that you are developing. Include how the experience you have described

so far in your narrative CV has supported your career aspiration.

Describe the potential impact of this award on your career and how it will support your stated aspirations.

Support and mentorship

The 'Support and mentorship' section asks some questions about the individuals that will support you to undertake your award.

Description of support provided by supervisors and mentors

Your proposed support and mentorship team should provide support throughout the award in both your research endeavours and your overall career development. It is a 2-way process that may be challenging for both parties. For this reason, choosing who will provide research support will require a great deal of thought.

The individuals who provide your supervision or mentorship should have a clear understanding of:

- the research process
- the demands your chosen area of training and development are likely to place on you
- your strengths and weaknesses

Please note, in the 'Budget' section, you can only apply for funding to cover your travel and subsistence costs to visit your mentors or supervisors. You cannot include any costs for your mentors or supervisors.

Please provide details of your proposed mentorship team designating each member as a 'mentor' on the application form and describe the support they will provide.

You should clearly describe how the proposed arrangements will support your overall development and provide an initial assessment of the time that will be allocated to the research support process

You must identify at least 1 research mentor and a maximum of 4 research mentors to support you throughout your award. At least 1 research mentor should be based in your contracting organisation. You may also wish to choose a mentor from another organisation elsewhere in the UK.

If you are developing a practitioner academic career or requesting salaried practice time within the award, you should also include details of one or more individuals who will provide professional practice support. These individuals should be designated as ‘practice supervisors’ to differentiate them from your academic mentors.

Add a supervisor or mentor

You will need to invite your proposed supervisors or mentors. They will need to respond and confirm their role in your application. Please ensure that you have agreement from individuals before adding them to the application.

To add a supervisor or mentor:

1. Use the envelope button to add a supervisor or mentor; this will open a table in a new window
2. Click the plus icon within the ‘Invitations’ pop-out
3. Fill in the name, email address and role of your supervisor or mentor
4. Click the ‘Invite’ option to email an invitation to your supervisor or mentor. If you are not yet ready to send an invitation, you can select ‘save’ instead
5. Your supervisor or mentor will receive an email invitation to be added to your application

Once your supervisor or mentor has confirmed their role, they will appear in the support and mentorship table. You will then both be able to edit the information about the support they will provide.

Proposed supervisors and mentors will be asked to provide an ORCID number. Funding committee reviewers may look at the proposed supervisor or mentor's profile when assessing their suitability for the role. We advise you to ask your proposed supervisors or mentors to ensure their ORCID profile is up to date.

All participants and signatories named in your application must validate their NIHR award management accounts. You will not be able to submit your application if accounts are not fully activated.

Application details

This information relates to the 'Application details' tab in the application system.

Scientific abstract (3,500 characters)

The scientific abstract should be a clear and concise summary of your detailed research plan.

You might want to include the following elements and headings in your scientific abstract:

- research question
- background
- aims and objectives
- methods
- timelines for delivery
- knowledge mobilisation, dissemination and impact

- research inclusion

What you include may depend on the design of your research, the setting and the programme you are applying to. It might also depend on whether your research is primary research or evidence synthesis. You will need to decide which elements to include and there may be others not mentioned here. You might find the guidance on the [EQUATOR Network website](https://www.equator-network.org/) (<https://www.equator-network.org/>) useful.

Plain English summary (3,500 characters)

You will need to write a clear and easy-to-read summary about your proposed research. This is different from a scientific abstract. Please do not copy and paste sections from your scientific abstract or detailed research plan.

Your plain English summary will be read by people reviewing your application who may not have specialist knowledge of your research field. If your application is successful, your summary will be used on NIHR and other websites. If we feel your summary is not clear enough, we may ask you to amend it before we approve funding.

Please [see our guidance on how to write a plain English summary](/plain-english-summaries) (</plain-english-summaries>).

Working with people and communities summary (3,500 characters)

Please summarise how you will ensure the different stages of your research lifecycle are directly shaped and influenced by the lived experience of diverse people and communities who will be affected by it. Any information on patient and public involvement should be summarised here. Full information about what NIHR is looking for in this section can be found in our [guidance on working with people and communities](/research-funding/application-support/working-with-people-and-communities) (</research-funding/application-support/working-with-people-and-communities>), alongside further resources.

You will need to signpost here to sections of your detailed research plan where you describe how you will work with people and communities in more detail.

Detailed research plan (maximum 10 pages)

You should ensure that the information you include is accurate, succinct, clearly laid out and provides sufficient methodological detail.

Please download the template 'Detailed research plan' from within the awards management system. There are 6 sections within this template, which must all be completed. Section headings and margins should not be amended in any way. Upload a maximum of 10 pages.

If necessary to clarify your research you may embed:

- schematics
- tables
- illustrations
- graphs
- other types of graphics

Please ensure that your research plan uses Arial size 12 font and no smaller, and shows page numbers within the document footer. Once you have completed the research plan template offline, please convert it into a PDF before uploading into the system to ensure formatting is consistent. Please do not delete the PDF version that the system creates and adds to your application, unless you wish to remove or replace your detailed research plan entirely and re-upload it.

All research funded by the NIHR as part of a personal career development award must fall within our [remit for personal awards](/career-development/nihr-academy/remit-personal-awards) (/career-development/nihr-academy/remit-personal-awards).

Background and rationale

Describe the background and rationale for the proposed research. You should include the following information:

- a description of how your project addresses the aims of the funding opportunity
- an explanation of the health or social care problem being addressed and how the project responds to gaps in knowledge and addresses inequalities or the needs of under-served populations, or both
- where appropriate, an explanation of why your research is important, the need for it, and the impact it could have. Please consider the impact the research could have on those most affected. For example members of the public and communities; practitioners; service planners and decision makers; workforce and policy makers and others
- information on how the existing literature or evidence base, or both, supports your application, and how it fills an evidence gap. We will only fund primary research where the proposed research is informed by a review of the existing evidence

Aims and objectives

Summarise the questions and key aims and objectives of your project. These should map to the intended outcomes and impact of your research as described in your detailed research plan.

Methodology/plan

The methodology or plan is where you describe your proposed design and methodology in detail.

You will need to include details about:

1. Project design and methods
2. Timeline and milestones

In your methodology and plan you will also need to include the following information:

3. Working in partnership with those affected by your research

Describe your plans for ensuring that the different stages of your research or award lifecycle are directly shaped and influenced by the relevant lived experiences and needs of those who will be affected by it.

Those affected by research include:

- people and communities (working with people and communities is a requirement of NIHR funding)
- members of the health and care workforce, service planners and decision makers, policy makers or others

Your response should address:

- who has shaped this proposal so far, why and how
- who will be involved throughout the research/award lifecycle, why and how

Your plans should be appropriate for the type of award and proportionate to your proposed budget and resources.

Please check the individual funding opportunity page for any specific requirements for working with people and communities.

Any information on patient and public involvement should be included here. Please see our [guidance for working with people and communities \(/research-funding/application-support/working-with-people-and-communities\)](#) for more information.

4. Inclusive research

You must detail how you have considered inclusive research design and sex and gender throughout the whole research lifecycle.

Inclusion needs to be embedded in the research design, including:

- the development of the research question
- the research population
- the research methods
- data collection and statistical analysis
- knowledge mobilisation and dissemination of findings

See our [inclusive research funding application guidance \(/about-us/who-we-are/research-inclusion/funding-application-guidance\)](#) for more information about what to include in your application.

You should fully cost the inclusive research design and sex and gender elements of your application. Provide information and justify costs associated with inclusive design and sex and gender elements in the finance section of the application form.

Knowledge mobilisation, dissemination and impact

Explain your plan for knowledge mobilisation, dissemination and impact. You will need to show how you will reach and actively mobilise knowledge with your key stakeholders and knowledge users throughout the research cycle. Explain your anticipated knowledge mobilisation activities for achieving your intended outcomes

and impact. Please include the following in your explanation:

1. The intended outcomes and impact of your research
2. Who the key stakeholders and knowledge users are
3. How you will achieve intended outcomes and impact

You are encouraged to provide a schematic diagram outlining the logic underpinning how your research will achieve the intended research outcomes and impact. Please refer to the funding opportunity guidance and the relevant funding programme theory of change or logic model where this is available. Give an account of how the knowledge mobilisation activities will strengthen and facilitate the impact pathway.

1. The evidence you will gather to demonstrate the extent to which your research and knowledge mobilisation activities have achieved their intended outcomes and impact.

See our [plan knowledge mobilisation \(/research-funding/application-support/plan-knowledge-mobilisation\)](/research-funding/application-support/plan-knowledge-mobilisation) page for further guidance.

Project management

You will need to include details of how your project will be managed. Effective project management is essential, particularly if your project involves a number of institutions or component parts. This will ensure the work is completed within the planned timeframe.

Intellectual property and commercialisation

[Intellectual property \(IP\) \(/research-funding/application-support/designing-your-research/intellectual-property\)](/research-funding/application-support/designing-your-research/intellectual-property) is an important tool to deliver benefits to patients and

communities. It can take a wide range of forms, including patents, trademarks, designs and copyright. Copyright can include outputs such as databases, software, checklists, protocols and manuscripts. IP can include know-how arising from the research, or trade secrets, for example in research tools like data analysis techniques, cell lines and biomarkers.

This will normally include details of the following:

- IP created before your application and potential future IP resulting from your project. This should include who owns the pre-existing IP. You should also detail whether any patent applications have been made or patents granted relating to the proposed work.
- any third-party IP licensing involved. This could be arising from an existing licence or one that is required to undertake the project.
- future IP management including capturing, managing, and using the resulting IP from your project. This includes the possibilities of IP and commercial use.
- commercial partners, their roles and expected use from the research outputs.

Please also consider including the following information if applicable:

- the results of Freedom to Operate (FTO) checks. This includes any searches with details of who carried them out.
- the market competitiveness of your proposed technology, and how it compares to existing products. This should also include its innovation level and competitive advantages.
- how you will ensure your outputs are used in healthcare or social care. Include how you will overcome any barriers and meet regulations. You should also

include requesting formal evaluation from national policy bodies, such as the National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE).

- the impact of your product on health and social care.
- the novelty of your output, dissemination or strategies regarding market entry anticipated reach.

IP applies to all NIHR funded research. For more information about IP, see our [IP and commercialisation guidance \(/about-us/who-we-are/policies-and-guidelines/intellectual-property-and-commercialisation-guidance\)](/about-us/who-we-are/policies-and-guidelines/intellectual-property-and-commercialisation-guidance).

Career development programme (maximum 3 pages)

You are required to upload details of your proposed career development programme as part of your application.

Please download the template 'Career development programme' from within the awards management system and re-upload it when finalised. Upload 3 single-side A4 pages as a .pdf document when you have completed the template. If your career development programme exceeds the maximum 3 pages, your application will not be accepted. You must not amend section headings and margins in any way. Use Arial size 12 font. If a heading is not applicable to your career development programme, leave it blank.

Your career development programme upload should detail the training and development you are proposing to undertake as part of your award. You should cover 2 types of training. The first is training you may need to undertake to complete the proposed research. The second is training to support your broader academic career development as a future health and care research leader.

The training you include should support your specific needs and career goals. It should complement the research proposed in your application. It may include, but is not limited to:

- formal courses
- training in specialist skills and research methodologies
- placements with other research groups or centres
- leadership skills
- conference attendance
- overseas research visits

Your career development programme could also include gaining education and teaching skills. For example, completing a Postgraduate Certificate in Academic Practice. However, educational training should not make up the majority of your programme. The focus should be on research and leadership training.

To meet the NIHR research inclusion requirements for this award, you should consider training that supports the development of your understanding of inclusion in research. This could include, but is not limited to, training on health and care inequalities, or training on a specific group or community that you intend to work with. There is more information on our [inclusive research page \(/about-us/who-we-are/research-inclusion\)](/about-us/who-we-are/research-inclusion).

We encourage our award holders to develop new international research collaborations. This means we will consider placements overseas and associated costs for up to 6 months in total. [We are aware that not all applicants will be in a position to undertake an overseas visit. If that is the case, we encourage you to consider alternative ways to support the development of collaboration.

Practice time and training

This award supports clinicians, practitioners, and individuals employed within a local authority setting to propose spending a percentage of salaried award time undertaking practice and associated training and professional development.

If you are requesting funded time dedicated to practice or clinical service to be included in your award, please detail how your proposed clinical or practice time will complement the research career you are developing.

If you propose salaried practice time within award time, we expect this time to be spent in a supernumerary practice role. The role should have been arranged, with your involvement, to maximise the experience that it will give you.

You are not limited to practice within a single setting. We encourage you to negotiate as diverse a range of responsibilities as is appropriate, perhaps through a range of secondments. You should provide a description of these planned activities in your career development programme.

If you request funding for clinical or professional training, you should describe and justify that training here. We advise you to take your current skill level into account and to propose a professional training and development plan that is appropriate to your level of seniority as a practitioner.

Budget

This information relates to the 'Budget' tab in the application system.

Application budget

Please click on the 'Open' button to complete the high-level budget summary in the pop-out. This is where you will need to give an overview of the costs associated with undertaking your award. This should relate to the activities you described in your proposal.

You should add costs to your application at current rates. See below for details of the funding available through this award and details of budget limits. You must also refer to our [finance guidance \(/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants\)](/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants) when preparing your budget.

If you are successful in obtaining funding, you will be asked for full budget details at a later stage.

When completing the 'Budget' section of your application, you must request funding under the correct headings. You must also enter costs at the rate at which they will be funded.

Funding rates

The Postdoctoral Award funds training and development costs and conference costs at 100% for all contracting organisation types.

The funding rates for all other costs are determined by organisation type, full details are available in the Direct and Indirect Funding rates section of our [finance guidance \(/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants#tab-direct-and-indirect-funding-rates\)](/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants#tab-direct-and-indirect-funding-rates). In summary the Postdoctoral Award funding rates are as follows:

NHS

- Direct costs: funded at 100% for all
- Reasonable Indirect costs: 0% for all

HEI

- Direct costs: funded at 80%
- Indirect costs: funded at 80%

Commercial, charity or non-governmental organisation, local authority and independent research organisations

- Direct: 100% for all

- Reasonable indirect: 0% for all

International

- Direct: 100% for all
- Reasonable indirect: 0% for all

Once you have added your costs overview, click 'Save' before returning to the 'Budget' screen.

Please note that, if successful, the total value of funding requested at the application stage cannot be increased when submitting the subsequent detailed budget. You must ensure that you have worked with your finance teams to determine the costs of the proposed award accurately. Even though a detailed budget is not required at the application stage, increases in budget if awarded will not be supported other than in exceptional circumstances.

You can request:

- your salary as the lead applicant, including clinical service or practice time
- the cost of a tailored academic and professional development programme
- annual conference budget
- research project costs which can include
 - a support post salary
 - plus £3,000 towards their training and development
 - shared staff costs

The Postdoctoral Award does not have strict budgetary limits except for research staff costs, clinical trials unit charges and conference costs, which are detailed below.

Budget limits

Conference fees and related costs

You can include reasonable conference costs up to £2,000 per full-time equivalent year. This can include costs such as registration fees, travel and subsistence.

Please note that conference costs are funded at 100% regardless of organisation type.

Research support post and their training and development budget

The award offers a support post to assist with your research. This is usually limited to the equivalent of 1 full-time member of staff for a period of 3 years. If your requirement is beyond this limit, your contracting organisation must provide the additional funding and your application should explain why you need the extra support.

In addition to their salary costs, we also provide funding towards their training and development needs up to £3,000.

If the support post is undertaking a PhD, you can also include the published HEI standard UK or home rate PhD fees.

Shared staff and clinical trials unit (CTU) costs

In addition to the 3-year full-time equivalent (fte) support post, you can also include part-time shared staff costs to support research activities. For example, part-time support from a trial manager, a database manager, or a statistician are all eligible

costs.

The level of shared staff required will depend on the scope and type of your project, as well as your experience and training needs. For example, a senior applicant may want to hand over some of the day-to-day tasks to allow them to focus on a development opportunity. In comparison, an applicant with less research experience may benefit from being involved in all tasks and, therefore, will require less shared staff time.

The time commitment of individual shared staff members should not exceed 30% fte and the total combined time commitment should generally not exceed the equivalent of 1 full-time member of staff for your award duration.

Enter shared staff costs in the 'Staff Costs' section and include the basic salary and on-costs for each staff member involved. In the justification section, you should clearly outline each staff member's role within the context of your career development award application and the time they will spend on the award.

For shared staff who are CTU staff, you can also include overheads such as estates and indirect costs, but you must include them separately from the salary costs. They should not exceed 40% of the total CTU staff cost.

You can also include non-staff costs for the CTU, such as randomisation services and clinical data management software licence fees. These costs should be detailed under the 'other direct costs' section

When working with a CTU, you should agree on costs with them before you submit your application.

Ineligible shared staff costs

We reserve the right to question excessive costs and will not fund:

- contributions for individuals providing support and mentorship, including:
 - mentors
 - supervisors
 - practice supervisors named in the application
 - administrative or secretarial support
 - whole or significant percentages of support posts over and above those permitted
 - technical or research support staff whose costs are funded through institutional indirect costs (HEIs only)
 - mentor travel expenses
-

Schedule of Events Cost Attribution Tool (SoECAT) (if applicable)

A SoECAT will be required if the planned intervention or research activity will have a direct impact on participant care during the active phase of the award. Please upload the SoECAT funder export after it has been signed off by the AcoRD specialist. If you are unsure whether a SoECAT is needed, please refer to our [finance guidance \(/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants\)](#) for further information.

Additional support

We understand that some applicants may need some additional support to undertake a programme of career development. You can request costs to enable this type of additional support requirement. For example, this could include:

- financial support towards care costs for you, or any direct dependents, beyond your usual care costs normally incurred that arise as a result of activities undertaken during

the award

- additional support to remove barriers you face as a result of a disability or health condition, specifically to undertake the proposed research or training plan, in addition to the support you receive as an employee at your organisation

Reasonable adjustments

Costings for reasonable adjustments that you, or any co-applicants may require, should be included under 'Other direct costs', not under 'Research inclusion'. See our [finance guidance \(/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants#tab-costing-assumptions\)](/research-funding/application-support/guidance/finance-guidance-for-applicants#tab-costing-assumptions) for more information.

Under justification of costs, please state 'reasonable adjustments'. You should not disclose detailed information of reasonable adjustments required to undertake the award. We will discuss this with you further if your application is successful.

Justification of costs (5000 characters)

Please describe the type of costs you are requesting and why. Give as much detail as possible about how you have arrived at particular category costs.

Uploads

This information relates to the 'Uploads' tab in the application system.

Please convert all document types to PDF format before uploading into the system, to ensure formatting is consistent. If you upload a Word document (.doc or .docx), the system will create a PDF version of it which may display formatting differently. Both the Word document and system PDF will appear in the 'Uploads' section. Please do not delete the PDF versions that the system creates and adds to your application, unless you wish to remove or replace any of your uploads entirely, in which case you will need to delete both versions.

Gantt chart or project management plan (maximum 1 page)

Please attach a Gantt chart indicating a schedule for the completion of work, including the timing of key milestones and deliverables.

References (maximum 3 pages)

Upload a maximum of 3 single-side A4 pages in a .pdf document, using Arial size 12 font, listing references used throughout your application. Please include the Digital Object Identifier (DOI) of the main related publications. Please use the Harvard or Vancouver referencing style.

You must not upload letters of reference or letters of recommendation in this section. If unsolicited documents are uploaded here we may reject your application.

Contracting organisation letter of support (3 pages)

We see the responsibility for training the next generation of research leaders as a joint enterprise with contracting organisations. As such, you are required to upload a letter of support from your contracting organisation. If you have named a partner organisation, you will need to upload a separate letter from that organisation. You must not provide any additional letters of support. If unsolicited documents are uploaded here we may reject your application.

The letter(s) must:

- detail how the organisation(s) will support you to complete your award
- be tailored to you, your research and your training needs
- include how the organisation will support the long-term development of your research career
- evidence how the organisation(s) support early career researchers

- describe how the contracting organisation creates and maintains an inclusive and supportive research culture for all
- provide evidence of how the organisation values and supports equality, diversity and inclusion
- acknowledge the organisation's responsibilities around research integrity

Letters may wish to refer to the principles and best practice outlined within relevant charters and concordats in these areas, such as the Researcher Development Concordat and Advance HE's Equality Charters. Please note that being a signatory to concordats or holding bronze or silver status from the Equality Charters isn't a requirement of funding and evidence can be provided through other means.

Contracting organisations are expected to comply with the relevant principles and obligations for clinical academic training. We recommend that both your contracting and partner organisations read these documents before completing the statement of support:

- for [medics and dentists \(/uk-clinical-academic-training-medicine-and-dentistry-principles-and-obligations-march-2018\)](#)
- for [nurses, midwives, allied health professionals \(AHPs\) and other health and care professions \(/uk-clinical-academic-training-nurses-midwives-ahps-and-other-health-and-care-professionals-principles-and-obligations\)](#) including:
 - pharmacists
 - healthcare scientists
 - social workers
 - other registered health, public health or social care professional

We expect that all commitments made to the applicant within this statement will be honoured for the lifetime of the award.

If you have had some post-doctoral research time and are applying for a Postdoctoral Award of more than 4 years, our funding committee will score in their assessment the ongoing commitment of your contracting organisation to you beyond the end of your award. For example, the potential of an ongoing post which includes research.

Devolved administration Letter of Support (maximum 1 page)

If you are applying from a devolved administration, you must also upload a formal letter on headed paper from the authorised representative. This representative, as detailed in the funding opportunity you are applying for, should confirm that they are aware of your application and will manage it should you be successful.

Do not upload a document if you are applying from England.

Acknowledgements and conflicts

This information relates to the 'Acknowledgement & conflicts' tab in the application system. This is where you need to declare any potential conflicts and confirm you have read our terms and conditions.

Potential conflicts

Please declare any conflicts or potential conflicts of interest that you may have in undertaking the work as described. This includes any relevant, non-personal and commercial interest that could be perceived as a conflict of interest. If in doubt, you should err on the side of disclosure.

I have read and understood the terms of applying as lead applicant and accept this role

As lead applicant, please tick the box to confirm that the information entered into the application form is correct and that you take responsibility for overall management and delivery of the work described.

Signatories

This information relates to the 'Signatories' tab in the application system.

Signatories will have responsibility for managing the contract if your application is successful. The following signatories must be added (1 of each type):

1. Contracting organisation signatory

This must be a representative of the Contracting organisation with the authority to agree to the award contract on behalf of the organisation if successful for example a head of department.

2. Partner organisation signatory (if applicable)

If a partner organisation is named in the application, a representative from that organisation with the appropriate authority must confirm their support for the undertaking of the award as described in the application.

You should add them to your application so that they can accept their participation and electronically sign the application after submission. Please ensure that you have agreement from signatories before adding them to the application.

How to add a signatory

1. Within each section of the 'Signatories' tab, use the envelope button to add a signatory.
2. Click the plus icon (+) within the 'Invitations' pop-out.
3. Fill in the name and email address of your signatory.
4. Once you have entered the signatory details, click the 'Invite' option to email an invitation to your signatory. If you are not yet ready to send an invitation, you can select 'Save' instead.

Once you have filled in all the required details, the signatories will receive an email invitation to be added to your application. You will not be able to submit your application until the status of the signatories show as 'Accepted'.

Please note, all participants and signatories named in your application must validate their award management accounts. Submission of your application will not be possible if accounts are not fully activated.

Signatory sign off requirements

Acceptance of the invitation does not count as signing the application. Once the application has been submitted, signatories will automatically be sent a request to formally sign it. They have up to 24 hours after the submission deadline to do this. You can find the date and time of the 'Signatory approval deadline' on the 'Funding opportunity information' page in the awards management system. If your signatory does not approve your application by the signatory deadline, your application will not be submitted and we will not consider it for funding.

More information and contact

[Postdoctoral Award: overview \(/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award\)](/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award)

[Postdoctoral Award: how to apply \(/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award/how-to-apply\)](/career-development/research-career-funding-programmes/postdoctoral/postdoctoral-award/how-to-apply)

Need more funding application guidance?

If you still feel unsure about how to complete your application, log in to the awards management system and raise a help ticket. Click 'Request help' which you can find at the top of each tab in the awards management system within your application.

Log in to the awards management system

(https://awardsmanagement.nihr.ac.uk/s_Login.jsp)